probing, responsible press not only keeps the public informed about what's going on in government, it can keep a watchful eye out to uncover corruption, waste, or mismanagement.

But an unfortunate phenomenon took root in Washington after Watergate. Understandably, the press—especially the White House press corps—was skeptical about what it was being told about presidential behavior. Some reporters in Washington became more vigorous in their investigative reporting, convinced that if there was one scandal, there were probably more.

As I have said, a free and aggressive press corps is essential to the health of our democracy. If the press does not tell us, who will? But with that freedom comes a special responsibility to be accurate and fair. The press should remember the great impact its words can have on a person's life. Sadly, the words *questioned about* sometimes translate into *guilty of* in the minds of readers and listeners. That does not mean that reporters shouldn't do their job. It just means they should be careful.

I understand that it is part of the job of the Washington press corps to pin down the president and report to the nation on what is really going on inside the White House. Inevitably, the relationship between the press and the president has adversarial moments. I always regretted those moments, however. We weren't hiding anything, and I was frustrated that I could never convince the press of that.

It bothered me, too, that, from time to time, some in the press seemed anxious to catch me making a mistake. I don't know any human being who hasn't made mistakes or misstatements from time to time; and this is especially likely when a person gives as many speeches and answers as many questions as a president does. Some in the press corps seemed to make a special effort to play "gotcha" with me, especially during a press conference. If they wanted to